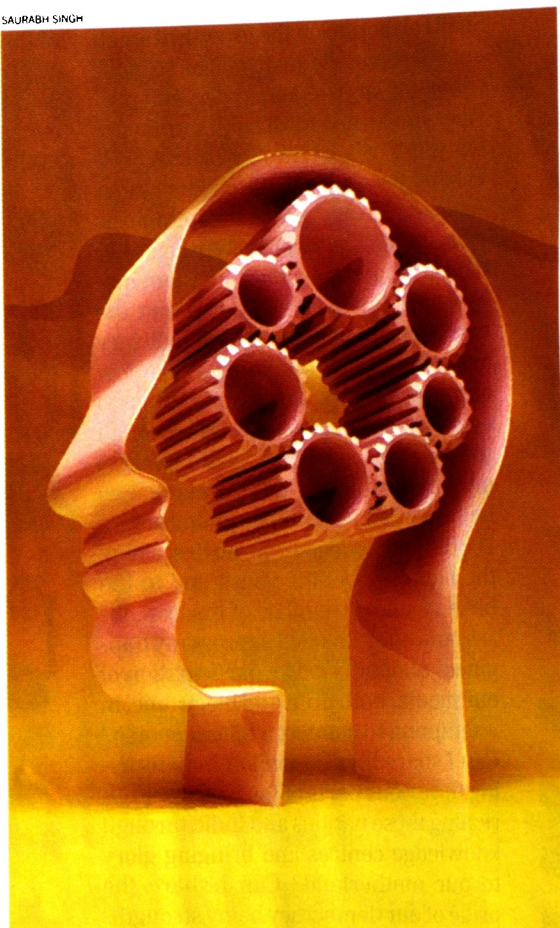


evolve strategies to realise it through their manifesto. As Edmond Burke told his electorate in 1774, "Parliament is not a congress of ambassadors from different and hostile interests but Parliament is a deliberative assembly of one nation, with one interest, that of the whole—you choose a member indeed but when you have chosen him, he is not member of Bristol but he is a Member of Parliament." These words hold true, centuries later and miles away in our land. Generally, citizens believe that the government has no shortage of programmes and funds. What needs improvement is the efficient and transparent delivery system, with a proper methodology for assessment, feedback and timely corrective action for full realisation of mission goals. A political will, spirit of working together backed by the enthusiasm of a "can-do" spirit can assure the success of mission. There are some examples of people who have made the impossible possible through their spirit and determination for uplifting society. M.R. Raju, a friend from Peddamiram, Andhra Pradesh, gave up his scientific pursuit in Los Alamos Laboratory, USA, and undertook the transformation of his village with the support of his family members. In the past decade, he has brought about a major change for the people in the village by providing treatment for cancer, eye care and also uplift of children in the age group of three to five. A confident young population is emerging in Peddamiram.

Another example is that of Baba Balbir Singh Seechewal who has rejuvenated the 175-km-long polluted and weed-choked Kali Bein river of Punjab within the last five years by deploying 3,000 volunteer pilgrims on an average despite severe opposition from many industries and vested interests. Today one can feel the flow of fresh water in this rivulet and also the con-

SAURABH SINGH



**In the 1990s, youth used to ask me,
"When can I sing the Song of India?"
Today, they ask me, "What can I give to
India?" This represents the New Spirit
of this New India.**

siderable rise of the water table in the adjoining fields.

A third example is that of S.R. Krishnamurthy who entered my room in Coimbatore in a wheelchair with cheerfulness radiating from him. I was amazed to see a physically challenged person with no legs, no hands. I asked him, please tell me, what I can do for you? He said, I do not want anything from you, only I would like to sing in front of you, and he sang melodiously Saint Thyagraja's *pancha ratna kriti entharo mahanubavulu* in Sriragam giving me a glimpse of his enormous talent. I was touched. What is the message? Despite being physically chal-

lenged, the latent talent of music could blossom in this person with his positive attitude and perseverance.

When I see the youth of the nation, I see in them the eternal spirit of Mahatma Gandhi, Rajendra Prasad, Jawaharlal Nehru, Sardar Patel, Subhash Chandra Bose, B. R. Ambedkar, Maulana Azad, Rajaji and many great visionary leaders of our nation. These leaders had unique leadership qualities. For them, nation was sacred and above any individual, organisation or political system.

Can our youth become such visionary leaders, putting the nation above themselves with determination and inspiration? For such a purposeful event, we need the initiative of the political leadership at the top to ignite the minds through a great vision of transforming India. For such a mission to happen, India's billion people have to work as one entity. This is possible only through Parliament which is constituted by the elected representatives of the country. Parliament should meet on August 15, 2008, to pledge that they will launch an action-oriented movement to transform India into an economically developed nation with a strong value system before the year 2020. Let us all

work together in this mission of re-igniting the Spirit of India and maintaining it. Let me conclude with a few verses from my poem:

Thoughts

Oh Almighty, Embed the thought
'Nation is bigger than the Individual'
in the minds of the leaders
and people.

Oh Almighty, Bless my people
to work with perseverance
to transform the country
into a peaceful and prosperous nation.

The author is former President of India